

Adrian Vellum

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling had privately informed you that tonight's gift would come with a new governance agreement: he wanted veto power over acquisitions, his name on the museum, and your resignation within sixty days. You smiled through the meeting and told no one.

What you are hiding

You have already accepted a confidential offer to lead a rival museum next year, which makes any argument with Sterling look like succession planning. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Margot has seen the governance addendum.
- Quietly learn whether Celeste would stay if you left.
- Do not volunteer your job offer unless pressure forces it.

What you know about other guests

- Margot showed you a draft indicating Sterling's gift could give him extraordinary governance power.
- Sterling personally ordered Everett to take the Donor Salon camera offline for private meetings.
- Sterling threatened to withhold Lucian Gable's final design payment unless he accepted a last-minute display change.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You entered the Donor Salon at 6:32 to replace Sterling's speech cards. At 6:40 you slipped into the museum office and took a confidential wired-landline call from the rival museum that has offered you a job; the call record runs continuously until 6:50. Revealing that record clears your timing but exposes your planned departure.

IF MURDERER

At 6:47 you returned to the Donor Salon under the pretense of correcting Sterling's speech cards. Furious at the takeover terms, you tipped the stolen toxin into his private cordial and wiped the stem with your pocket square. You left calmly and resumed hosting.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Yes, Sterling wanted my resignation, and yes, I already have another job lined up. That is what I was hiding. The museum landline shows I was on a confidential call with that rival institution from 6:40 until 6:50. I wanted out of Sterling's museum. I did not need him dead.

IF MURDERER

Sterling did not want to support the Meridian. He wanted to own it - the name, the board, the collection, and finally my chair. I went back to his salon, changed the speech cards, and changed one other thing. I poisoned the cordial he reserved for himself. Then I walked back into my own gala and kept smiling. For once, Sterling's money could not buy the ending.

Celeste Frame

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

You discovered that Sterling knew the Star Bowl's provenance file contained a major gap and ordered the exhibition to proceed anyway. He threatened to remove you from the show if you raised the issue publicly.

What you are hiding

Against board instructions, you commissioned an independent provenance review and hid the preliminary report in the Registrar's Office. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Marcus has seen the same gap you found.
- Learn who wrote the anonymous warning note.
- Keep your independent report secret until you decide whom to trust.

What you know about other guests

- Rafael told you Sterling pressured him to soften a conservation report.
- Marcus believes Sterling has suppressed provenance research connected to at least two Voss objects.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You were in the Donor Salon at 6:25 correcting an object label. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Registrar's scanner log shows your curator code repeatedly scanning the independent provenance report you were not authorized to commission. Revealing the log clears your timing but exposes the report.

IF MURDERER

At 6:44 you used a label correction as an excuse to enter the Donor Salon. Believing Sterling was about to lock dubious objects permanently into the museum, you poisoned his cordial and returned to the gallery before anyone noticed.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I hid an independent provenance report because Sterling ordered me not to commission one. That was insubordination, not murder. The Registrar's scanner log shows me copying that report throughout the critical window. I was prepared to embarrass Sterling with evidence; I was not prepared to kill him for it.

IF MURDERER

Sterling knew exactly what the provenance file did not prove. He wanted my name on the label anyway so that scholarship could launder possession into legitimacy. I chose the moment he was alone, poisoned the cordial, and returned to the gallery. I told myself I was protecting the museum. I was really deciding that I knew better than the law.

Grant Easel

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling had learned that one certificate in a major private sale you brokered was forged before it ever reached you. He planned to imply publicly that you had created it unless you refunded him millions.

What you are hiding

You were duped on that sale, but you quietly altered your own file afterward so clients would not see how badly your due diligence failed. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Learn whether Conrad knows about the disputed certificate.
- Keep Theo from discussing the 'auction incident' in public.
- Figure out what Nadia knows about the Geneva freeport records.

What you know about other guests

- Theo was the anonymous buyer who outbid Sterling in the auction everyone whispers about.
- Conrad arranged at least one unusually discreet private sale for Sterling outside normal auction-house procedure.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You entered the Donor Salon at 6:34 to leave an appraisal folder and briefly handled a decorative decanter that looked like Sterling's service piece. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Media Room document terminal shows you revising and reprinting the disputed sale file you secretly altered. The audit trail clears your timing but exposes your cover-up.

IF MURDERER

At 6:43 you returned with a revised appraisal folder. You used the lookalike decanter as cover while slipping the toxin directly into Sterling's silver coupe, then wiped the stem before leaving.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I altered my own file because I was embarrassed that a forged certificate passed my desk. Sterling was using that mistake to extort a refund and my silence. The Media Room terminal audit shows me revising that very file throughout the poisoning window. I was covering up a professional humiliation, not a murder.

IF MURDERER

Sterling had enough money to survive any mistake. He wanted mine to destroy me instead. I went back with the appraisal folder, poisoned his silver coupe, and relied on one true fact - that I had already touched a lookalike decanter - to muddy the rest. In my business, provenance is everything. Tonight I created my own missing gap.

Margot Ledger

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling demanded that you disguise several gala and naming-wing expenses inside restricted museum funds until his promised donation cleared. When you resisted, he threatened to blame the bookkeeping on you.

What you are hiding

You temporarily moved money between internal accounts to cover a cash-flow shortfall, intending to reverse it after the gala. It was technically unauthorized and Sterling discovered it. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Helena has seen Sterling's draft funding agreement.
- Keep Adrian from learning about the temporary transfer unless absolutely necessary.
- Identify who found the donor ledger during the scavenger hunt.

What you know about other guests

- Adrian's future at the museum is threatened by Sterling's proposed governance agreement.
- Maya's education program would lose funding under one version of Sterling's gift conditions.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You met Sterling at 6:33 for a signature. From 6:40 to 6:50, the finance terminal audit shows you reversing and re-entering the unauthorized internal transfer you were trying to hide. That audit trail clears your timing but exposes the accounting violation.

IF MURDERER

At 6:46 you returned to obtain the signature Sterling had withheld. When he mocked the accounting mess he had helped create, you poisoned his cordial. You then copied a budget sheet to create the impression your office visit happened earlier.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I moved restricted funds without authorization. I intended to put every dollar back, and Sterling planned to make me the villain. The finance terminal audit shows me correcting that transfer throughout the poisoning window. That secret is ugly enough. It is not murder.

IF MURDERER

Sterling created the problem, ordered me to hide it, and then prepared to sacrifice me for it. When he refused the signature that would have protected the museum, I poisoned his drink. Then I used the copier clock to manufacture an earlier paper trail. I have spent my career making numbers reconcile. Tonight I made a life disappear instead.

Rafael Gilt

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling pressured you to soften a conservation report showing that one supposedly untouched object had been recently altered. He threatened to replace you with a private conservator if you refused.

What you are hiding

You changed the date on a minor treatment record last month to spare the museum an embarrassing insurance dispute. No object was harmed, but the falsification could end your career. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Calvin has noticed the altered treatment date.
- Ask Marcus what he thinks the Star Bowl's modern adhesive means.
- Keep the insurance issue separate from the murder investigation.

What you know about other guests

- Celeste quietly commissioned an outside provenance review despite pressure to stop asking questions.
- Calvin concealed a small installation crack until you could inspect it after opening night.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You had legitimate access to the conservation cabinet. During the entire poison window, the Conservation Lab data logger records a sequence of manual humidity-calibration entries under your personal code at the case across the house. The log clears your timing but also exposes the treatment record whose date you altered.

IF MURDERER

You took the toxin sample from the conservation cabinet earlier. At 6:42, while carrying a condition-report folder to Sterling, you added it to his cordial and disposed of the stopper in your glove pouch.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I falsified a treatment date to avoid an insurance fight. That was wrong, and Sterling knew enough to threaten me with it. The Conservation Lab data logger records my manual calibration entries throughout the poison window. I was hiding bad paperwork, not handling Sterling's glass.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted conservation to become theater: clean labels, clean stories, no inconvenient evidence. The toxin was already in my care. I brought him the report, poisoned the cordial, and left with the same steady hands I use on fragile things every day. I preserve objects for a living. I decided Sterling Voss was not one of them.

Imogen Muse

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling appropriated the concept for one of your unreleased performances and planned to unveil a sanitized version of it as the gala's closing spectacle, crediting himself as creative patron.

What you are hiding

You wrote and planted the ominous anonymous warning note about 'returning what was taken.' It was meant as an art-world provocation, not a literal threat. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Enjoy watching people overreact to your warning note without admitting you wrote it.
- Find out whether Riley changed the lighting cue you designed.
- Get Julian to admit he still owes you credit for an old collaboration.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling's gala spectacle borrows heavily from an unreleased performance concept you created.
- Sterling owns a humiliating student painting Julian desperately does not want displayed tonight.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You entered the Donor Salon earlier to leave a small silver performance prop. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Media Room printer log shows you producing revised copies of the anonymous 'return what was taken' note you planted as part of your provocation. The print history clears your timing but reveals that the creepy warning was yours.

IF MURDERER

At 6:45 you carried a silver prop into the Donor Salon as cover. You used it to stir the toxin into Sterling's cordial, wiped it, and returned to Avery only moments later.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I wrote the creepy note. I wanted Sterling's grand unveiling to feel morally haunted, not literally haunted. That was the performance. The Media Room printer log shows me revising and printing it throughout the poison window. My crime tonight was pretension.

IF MURDERER

Sterling stole the piece, sanded off its teeth, and planned to present himself as the visionary behind it. So I gave him one final private performance. I carried in the silver prop, stirred poison into the cordial, and walked back into the gallery as if nothing had happened. The title, if anyone asks, is Patron, Interrupted.

Julian Brush

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling owned an embarrassing student painting you have spent years trying to buy back. He planned to display it tonight beside your celebrated recent work as a joke about 'humble beginnings.'

What you are hiding

You have secretly used buyers to acquire several of your own early paintings so you could remove them from circulation. The art world would find that both vain and market-manipulative. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Daphne knows you were behind the anonymous buybacks.
- Persuade Celeste that the student painting should not be displayed.
- Avoid giving Morgan Slate a quote you will regret.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling owns one of your embarrassing student paintings and has been discussing displaying it.
- Imogen has been furious that the gala spectacle resembles an unreleased concept of theirs.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Cobalt pigment from your jacket appears on the drink tray because you signed a catalogue there earlier. During the poison window, the Registrar's copier records you scanning proxy-purchase paperwork connected to your secret campaign to buy back your own early paintings. The log clears your timing but exposes the buybacks.

IF MURDERER

At 6:44 you entered with a signed sketch for Sterling. You poisoned the cordial and wiped the glass, but a fleck of your distinctive cobalt studio pigment transferred from your cuff to the stem.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Yes, I have been buying back my own early work. Vanity is legal. Sterling planned to humiliate me with a student painting, and I hated him for it. The Registrar's copier log shows me scanning the proxy-buyer paperwork throughout the poison window. I was hiding vanity, not murder.

IF MURDERER

Sterling thought ownership gave him the right to define me forever. He planned to turn my worst student painting into a punch line beside the work I fought to become capable of making. I brought him a sketch, poisoned the cordial, and wiped the glass. I missed one fleck of cobalt. Apparently every artist leaves a signature.

Helena Cross

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

You wrote a private legal memorandum concluding that the Star Bowl's acquisition was too risky to defend confidently. Sterling forced you to replace it with a softer opinion and planned to cite your name during the announcement.

What you are hiding

Both versions of the memo still exist. You kept the original instead of destroying it, which could expose you to professional embarrassment and Sterling to serious scrutiny. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Learn whether Vivienne has obtained a copy of your original memo.
- Keep Marcus from publicly speculating about your legal advice.
- Find out who has been searching the Registrar's Office.

What you know about other guests

- Vivienne's restitution negotiations would be badly damaged if Sterling announced permanent ownership tonight.
- Margot has been under unusual pressure over how Sterling wants his gift expenses classified.
- Sterling asked you how quickly he could seek an injunction against Nadia's upcoming investigation.

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

A torn corner of your legal pad was found in the salon from your 6:28 meeting with Sterling. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Registrar's secure printer and fax log show you reproducing and transmitting the harsher original legal memo you had been pressured to soften. The record clears your timing but exposes both versions.

IF MURDERER

At 6:46 you returned with the original memo and demanded Sterling change his announcement. When he refused, you poisoned his cordial. A torn corner from your pad remained beneath the decanter.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I wrote the first memo saying the acquisition was indefensible, and I let Sterling pressure me into softening it. I kept the original because I knew I might need the truth later. The secure printer and fax log shows me transmitting that original throughout the poison window. That is what I was protecting.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted my signature to transform risk into legitimacy. I gave him a final chance to change the announcement. He laughed. I poisoned the cordial, tore the note from my pad, and left. Lawyers are trained to live with ambiguity. I decided I could not live with his.

Dr. Marcus Pryce

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling suppressed your research showing that two objects in his collection passed through a dealer linked to questionable wartime sales. He threatened to release correspondence suggesting you had overstated another provenance claim if you challenged him publicly.

What you are hiding

One celebrated article of yours does contain an inference you stated too confidently. The main thesis still stands, but the mistake would be humiliating. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Ask Sebastian what he has discovered in the accession records.
- Determine whether Celeste commissioned outside provenance research.
- Keep Nadia from learning which article Sterling could attack.

What you know about other guests

- Celeste has doubts about the Star Bowl's provenance serious enough to seek independent review.
- Sebastian found an archival document that appears to contradict one exhibition label.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

A black-star archive seal from your research packet was found in the Donor Salon. During the poison window, the Media Room archive scanner records you copying correspondence related to the weak inference in your celebrated article. The scan sequence clears your timing but exposes the scholarly mistake Sterling was using against you.

IF MURDERER

At 6:43 you carried a research packet to Sterling. You poisoned the cordial after he refused to release the acquisition files. One black-star seal from your packet adhered beneath the tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Sterling had proof that I overstated one inference years ago. I was afraid he would use a real mistake to discredit research that threatened him. The archive scanner records me copying the correspondence behind that mistake throughout the poison window. That is embarrassing, but it clears me.

IF MURDERER

Sterling understood the power of uncertainty. He only needed one flaw in my record to bury everything else I had found. I brought him the file, poisoned his cordial, and left with the papers. One seal stayed behind. I spent my life reconstructing chains of custody. Mine ends here.

Sienna Voss

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling told you he intended to rewrite the family trust tonight, removing you from control of the charitable foundation unless you publicly backed his museum naming plan.

What you are hiding

You have been quietly organizing other family trustees to block Sterling's control over the foundation and redirect future giving toward worker and community programs. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Beatrice would publicly oppose renaming the museum.
- Gauge Adrian's willingness to reject Sterling's conditions.
- Do not reveal the trust fight unless you must.

What you know about other guests

- Theo's board ambitions have become personal because Sterling is quietly blocking him.
- Beatrice has always been uneasy about the paperwork on Sterling's earliest museum gifts.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You confronted Sterling privately at 6:30 and left angry. From 6:40 to 6:49, the donor-office scanner records you copying the draft trust documents you intended to use against him with the other trustees. The scan log clears your timing but exposes the family challenge.

IF MURDERER

You returned at 6:45 after learning the trust papers were ready. During the argument you slipped the toxin directly into Sterling's silver coupe and scratched its base with your signet ring while steadying it.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Sterling threatened to cut me out of the foundation because I would not help him turn philanthropy into obedience. I am organizing the trustees against him. The donor-office scanner shows me copying the trust papers throughout the poisoning window. I was building a case against him, not killing him.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted the family foundation to become another room he could lock from the inside. I went back after learning the trust papers were ready. I poisoned his silver coupe and scratched its base with my ring. He spent years teaching me that control was the only language power understood. I answered in it.

Everett Locke

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling ordered you to disable the Donor Salon camera because he planned several off-the-record meetings. He then told you that if anything went wrong tonight, security would 'own the failure.'

What you are hiding

You personally unplugged the camera despite museum policy. You did it under direct donor pressure and never documented the order. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out who knew the Donor Salon camera was offline.
- Keep the camera decision quiet until you understand the murder timeline.
- Ask Calvin whether anyone moved through the service corridor during Act I.

What you know about other guests

- Nadia tried to get private access to Sterling before dinner and was refused.
- Riley's last-minute lighting changes caused the eerie flicker some guests noticed during Act I.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Your master key opened the salon at 6:29 when you disabled the camera. During the poison window, the main security panel records manual system checks under your code every ninety seconds from a console physically located in the security station. The log clears your timing but also proves you violated policy by disabling the camera.

IF MURDERER

You used your master key at 6:46 to re-enter the camera-blind salon. Furious that Sterling planned to blame you for any problem, you poisoned his cordial and relied on the missing footage to protect you.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I shut off the camera because Sterling ordered me to. I should have documented it and I did not. That decision made the murder easier, which I will have to live with. The main security console records my manual checks every ninety seconds throughout the poisoning window. I never went back to the salon.

IF MURDERER

Sterling ordered me to blind the room and then told me security would take the fall if anything happened. He gave me the perfect crime scene himself. I went back with the master key, poisoned his drink, and trusted the dark camera to do exactly what he wanted: see nothing.

Nadia Quill

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

You were preparing a major investigation into Sterling's collection and labor empire. He discovered enough to threaten an injunction and promised to reveal the identity of one of your confidential museum sources if you published.

What you are hiding

You obtained internal documents through a source inside the Meridian. Protecting that source matters more to you than tonight's scoop. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Sterling found the full provenance spreadsheet or only excerpts.
- Keep your source's identity protected.
- Get Grant or Conrad to comment on the Geneva records without telling them what you know.

What you know about other guests

- Grant is vulnerable over a disputed authenticity certificate in an old private sale.
- Helena wrote a much harsher legal opinion on the Star Bowl before a softer version appeared.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You slipped into the Donor Salon at 6:31 hoping to interview Sterling and left when he refused. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Press Room scanner records you copying the confidential source documents behind your embargoed story. The scan log clears your timing but risks exposing how much internal material you possess.

IF MURDERER

At 6:47 you returned after Sterling threatened your source. You poisoned his cordial and then wrote a false earlier timestamp in your notebook to create distance from the salon.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

My source gave me documents Sterling desperately wanted buried. I went into his salon earlier to confront him, and I refused to name the source when he threatened me. The Press Room scanner log shows me copying those documents throughout the poisoning window. Protecting a source made me secretive, not murderous.

IF MURDERER

Sterling could survive the story. My source could not survive being exposed by him. I went back, poisoned his cordial, and falsified my notebook timeline. Journalists are supposed to protect sources without becoming the story. I failed that rule spectacularly.

Lucian Gable

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling demanded a dangerous last-minute change to the centerpiece display and threatened to withhold your firm's final payment if you refused. He also planned to blame you publicly for any flaw in the opening-night presentation.

What you are hiding

You signed off on one temporary lighting rig that did not fully meet your own design standard because there was no time to rebuild it before the gala. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Keep Rafael from turning the temporary rig into a formal safety dispute.
- Find out what Riley changed after your final walkthrough.
- Make Malcolm admit the entrance sculpture blocks the intended sight line.

What you know about other guests

- Riley changed a lighting cue after your final walkthrough.
- Sterling threatened Malcolm's final payment over the entrance commission.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Your brass screwdriver was found near the salon after circulating through installation work. During the poison window, the centerpiece lighting console records continuous manual adjustments under your designer code from the Grand Gallery. The console log clears your timing but exposes the unapproved temporary rig you signed off on.

IF MURDERER

At 6:45 you used a lighting check as cover to enter the salon. You poisoned Sterling's cordial and accidentally left your distinctive brass screwdriver near the service tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I signed off on a temporary lighting rig I hated because Sterling would not delay the opening. That is the professional compromise I was hiding. The lighting console records my continuous manual adjustments throughout the poison window. The screwdriver looks bad; the console log is better.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted spectacle without consequence, speed without responsibility, and my signature beneath both. I went in under cover of a lighting check, poisoned the cordial, and left my screwdriver behind like an amateur. Apparently even perfect sight lines have blind spots.

Vivienne Marrow

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling intended to announce that the Star Bowl would become a permanent Meridian holding, undermining months of quiet restitution negotiations and publicly humiliating the international partners you represent.

What you are hiding

You leaked the existence of the restitution talks to selected journalists to pressure Sterling, even though the negotiations were supposed to remain confidential. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Nadia knows you were the leak.
- Get Helena to acknowledge that the legal risk is real.
- Avoid turning the gala into a diplomatic incident unless Sterling's announcement forces you.

What you know about other guests

- Helena's original legal opinion was substantially more skeptical of the Star Bowl acquisition than the final version.
- Marcus believes Sterling has sat on provenance research that could embarrass the collection.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You delivered a formal letter to Sterling at 6:28. During the poison window, the Registrar's secure fax machine was transmitting your confidential restitution packet page by page under your authorization code. The transmission log clears your timing but exposes negotiations you were supposed to keep quiet.

IF MURDERER

At 6:46 you returned with a second envelope containing a final demand. When Sterling refused, you poisoned the cordial. You discarded the envelope after it picked up a drop from the drink.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I leaked the restitution talks because quiet diplomacy had become an excuse for endless delay. That breach of confidence is mine. The Registrar's secure fax log shows my restitution packet transmitting throughout the poisoning window. I broke confidence, not the law of life and death.

IF MURDERER

Sterling planned to turn a disputed object into a victory speech and months of negotiation into a public defeat. I brought him one final demand. He refused. I poisoned the cordial and discarded the stained envelope. Diplomacy failed, and I chose something much worse.

Theo Glass

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling had blacklisted you from a major acquisition after you outbid him anonymously for a work he wanted. Tonight he planned to announce that your collecting practices were 'speculative theater' and block your appointment to the museum board.

What you are hiding

You were the anonymous buyer in the auction incident everyone keeps referencing. You concealed your identity through Grant to avoid a bidding war with Sterling. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Keep Grant from revealing your role in the auction.
- Find out whether Adrian supports your board candidacy.
- Get Morgan Slate to admit the 'algorithm discovering patina' line was at least a little funny.

What you know about other guests

- Grant knows you were the anonymous buyer who beat Sterling at auction.
- Sterling bragged that he could rewrite the family trust if Sienna refused to support his museum plans.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Your cufflink did chip against the Grand Gallery rail. During the poison window, the collection scanner records you copying the auction invoice that proves you were the anonymous bidder who outbid Sterling. The scan sequence clears your timing but exposes the identity you hid through Grant.

IF MURDERER

At 6:44 you slipped into the Donor Salon to force a reconciliation before the announcement. You poisoned the cordial when Sterling refused. Your glass cufflink struck the service table and chipped; one fragment remained on the carpet.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I was the anonymous buyer who outbid Sterling, and I hid behind Grant because I knew Sterling would turn the sale into a personal war. He wanted to keep me off the board for it. The collection scanner shows me copying the auction invoice throughout the poison window. I was hiding a bidder's identity, not a murder.

IF MURDERER

Sterling could not stand losing an object he wanted, and he could not stand that I had beaten him without letting him know whom to punish. Tonight he planned to close the museum door in my face publicly. I went in to negotiate, poisoned his cordial when he refused, and broke my cufflink on the way out. Not exactly a clean exit.

Beatrice Plinth

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling planned to reveal that you accepted his first questionable donation in 1989 despite incomplete paperwork, staining the legacy you built.

What you are hiding

You did approve that accession because the museum was desperate for funds and you convinced yourself the paperwork would follow. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Sienna and Sterling have been fighting over the future of the Voss charitable foundation.
- The museum's 1989 accession paperwork for one early Voss gift was never as complete as you wished.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You were in the Grand Gallery telling Leo the story of the museum's founding during the key window; three people heard you.

IF MURDERER

At 6:45 you returned to the salon with your old accession notebook and poisoned his cordial after he threatened to make you the sole scapegoat.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I approved one of Sterling's early gifts before its paperwork was complete because the museum was desperate and I told myself the documents would follow. He planned to make that compromise my entire legacy. But Adrian and Leo heard me holding court in the Grand Gallery throughout the poisoning window. I made a bad museum decision in 1989. I did not make a murderer of myself tonight.

IF MURDERER

Sterling was going to expose a decision we both understood perfectly well in 1989 and rewrite it as my sin alone. I brought the old accession notebook to confront him, poisoned his cordial, and lost one page beneath the tray. I helped build this museum. I could not bear to let Sterling purchase the right to write its history.

Conrad Gavel

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling threatened to expose a private sale you arranged outside your auction house's normal process unless you waived a substantial fee.

What you are hiding

You did route the sale through a discreet subsidiary to satisfy a client who insisted on anonymity. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Grant once handled a disputed certificate that Sterling could use against him.
- Daphne quietly sold a work she had once spoken of as a future institutional gift.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You were loudly arguing with Grant about buyer premiums during the critical minutes, witnessed by Daphne.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:44 with a valuation sheet, poisoned the cordial, and left the auction pencil you used to stir it.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I arranged a private sale through a discreet subsidiary because a client demanded anonymity. Sterling knew and intended to use it to erase a fee he owed me. Unsavory, perhaps. Murderous, no. Grant and Daphne can both place me in a very public argument while the poison was added.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted a private transaction when it benefited him and a public scandal when it benefited him more. I brought the valuation sheet, stirred poison into his cordial with my auction pencil, and left the pencil behind. I have spent forty years telling people when the bidding is over. Tonight I ended it myself.

Investigation notes

Lola Loom

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling intended to purchase a family-owned ceremonial textile you had borrowed for your installation, despite your refusal to sell.

What you are hiding

The textile is in the exhibition without the full paperwork your family expected because you were afraid the loan would be denied. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Imogen's unreleased performance idea and the gala's closing spectacle look suspiciously similar.
- Julian has been using intermediaries to buy back some of his own early paintings.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Avery photographed you repairing a hanging thread in the gallery continuously through the key window.

IF MURDERER

You brought a textile swatch to Sterling at 6:46, poisoned his drink, and left a distinctive thread on the tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

The textile in my installation belongs to my family, and I brought it into the exhibition before every piece of loan paperwork was settled. Sterling wanted to buy it despite our refusal. That is what I was hiding. Julian and Imogen watched me repairing the installation while the poison was added.

IF MURDERER

Sterling treated a family object like everything else in his orbit: if he wanted it, refusal was merely a price negotiation. I brought him a swatch, poisoned his cordial, and left a thread behind on the glass. I wanted him to understand that not everything beautiful is available for purchase. I chose an unforgivable way to make the point.

Investigation notes

Sebastian Reed

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

You found an archival document that contradicted the Star Bowl label. Sterling told your department your fellowship could disappear if you pushed it.

What you are hiding

You have not yet told Marcus that your discovery also undermines one sentence in his published research. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Celeste commissioned independent provenance work outside the normal chain of approval.
- You found a source that complicates one published claim by your adviser Marcus.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Celeste was reviewing the disputed label with you during the entire critical window.

IF MURDERER

You used your student access badge to enter at 6:47, poisoned the cordial, and dropped an archival tab from your notes.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I found a document that complicates one of Marcus's published claims, and I had not yet told him. Sterling threatened my fellowship if I pushed the discovery. That is terrifying when you are twenty-four, but Celeste was reviewing the evidence with me throughout the poisoning window.

IF MURDERER

Sterling told me the truth could wait until I was no longer funded enough to find it. I used my access badge, went into the salon, poisoned his cordial, and dropped an archival tab from the very document he wanted buried. I wanted to prove I belonged in this field. This is not how.

Investigation notes

Malcolm Carrara

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling planned to replace your commissioned entrance sculpture with a cheaper replica after the opening and dispute your final payment.

What you are hiding

You built one internal support differently from the approved plan because the fabricator missed a deadline. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling has been threatening Lucian over the centerpiece installation and final payment.
- Sterling owns a student painting Julian desperately does not want exhibited.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Calvin and Lucian were with you moving a pedestal during the key window.

IF MURDERER

You entered the salon at 6:43 to demand payment, poisoned the cordial, and left marble dust from your cuff on the service cloth.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I changed an internal support in my sculpture because the fabricator missed a deadline. It is sound, but it is not exactly the approved plan. Sterling knew and planned to use that against my final payment. Lucian and the handling log place me elsewhere when the glass was poisoned.

IF MURDERER

Sterling planned to copy my commission, withhold my payment, and call the replica prudence. I confronted him, poisoned the cordial, and carried enough marble dust on my cuff to leave a trace on the glass. I make objects meant to outlive me. Sterling made sure this decision will too.

Investigation notes

Daphne Palette

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling knew you quietly sold a work you had publicly promised to donate to another institution and planned to expose the contradiction.

What you are hiding

You sold it to cover a failed business investment and hoped to replace it before anyone noticed. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Julian has been quietly buying back his own early work through proxies.
- Theo was the anonymous bidder who beat Sterling at the auction that damaged their relationship.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Theo and Grant were both with you discussing an auction lot during the key window.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:45 with a gift pledge, poisoned the drink, and left lipstick on the decanter stopper.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I sold a work I had once spoken of as a future donation because a business investment went badly, and I hoped to replace it before anyone noticed. Sterling planned to expose the contradiction. Theo and Grant can place me with them during the poisoning window. Hypocrisy, yes. Homicide, no.

IF MURDERER

Sterling loved philanthropy most when it made someone else look smaller. He was going to expose my broken promise as entertainment. I went to the salon with a pledge card, poisoned his cordial, and left a trace on the stopper. Taste can disguise many things. Apparently not this.

Investigation notes

Morgan Slate

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling discovered that you write an anonymous satirical newsletter skewering museum patrons and planned to unmask you during his speech.

What you are hiding

Several jokes in the newsletter came from private conversations, and you regret at least one of them. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling has been trying to block Theo from joining the museum board.
- Nadia is working on something far more serious than a gala review and Sterling knows it.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Nadia was arguing with you in the dining room throughout the critical minutes.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:44 to beg him not to expose you, poisoned the cordial, and left a torn draft joke in the bin.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I write the anonymous newsletter half this room pretends not to read. Some of its best lines came from private conversations, and Sterling planned to unmask me publicly. Nadia and I were busy arguing in the dining room while the cordial was poisoned. My weapon is usually a paragraph.

IF MURDERER

Sterling was going to put my name behind every anonymous line and let the room do the rest. I went in to bargain, poisoned his cordial when he refused, and tore up the draft I had brought with me. Critics are supposed to survive being disliked. I chose not to test that principle.

Investigation notes

Felix Savoy

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling had refused to approve the final catering invoice and planned to blame you for a last-minute service change he personally ordered.

What you are hiding

You changed his private beverage setup twice because Sterling and his assistant gave contradictory instructions. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling changed his private cordial instructions more than once during setup.
- Margot has been fighting with the donor office about who is actually paying for tonight's excesses.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Multiple staff and Riley place you at the buffet line during the critical minutes.

IF MURDERER

You were alone with the service tray at 6:46 and poisoned the cordial before sending it to the salon.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Sterling changed his beverage instructions twice, and I changed the setup twice. I was afraid every contradictory service note would make me look responsible. But Margot and my staff place me at the buffet while the poison was added. I served the drink. I did not poison it.

IF MURDERER

Sterling ordered changes, refused the invoice, and was preparing to blame service for whatever confused him next. I had the tray, the access, and one private return no one expected. I poisoned the cordial at 6:46 and walked back to the buffet. Hospitality is the art of anticipating needs. I anticipated one too many.

Investigation notes

Calvin Case

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling saw you damage a minor frame during installation and threatened to have you fired after the gala, despite the damage being repairable.

What you are hiding

You concealed the crack with a reversible mount until Rafael could inspect it after opening night. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling pressured Rafael to change how a conservation concern was described.
- Lucian's distinctive brass screwdriver passed through your hands during installation.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Rafael was with you adjusting a mount throughout the critical window.

IF MURDERER

You used the service corridor at 6:45, poisoned the cordial, and dropped a crate-seal tab beneath the tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I cracked a minor frame during installation and concealed it temporarily with a reversible mount until Rafael could inspect it. Sterling saw enough to threaten my job. Rafael was with me during the whole critical window. I hide damage for a living only until it can be repaired - not bodies.

IF MURDERER

Sterling was ready to turn one repairable mistake into the end of my career. I used the service corridor, poisoned his cordial, and dropped a crate-seal tab beneath the tray. I have moved objects worth more than I will ever earn without leaving a mark. Tonight I left one.

Investigation notes

Maya Bell

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling's gift conditions would cut public education programming to fund a private donor lounge and VIP entrance.

What you are hiding

You organized an anonymous staff petition against the plan and slipped copies into trustee folders. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- One draft of Sterling's gift would move money away from education and community programming.
- Adrian is under extraordinary pressure over Sterling's naming and governance demands.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Adrian and Riley both place you in the Grand Gallery during the key minutes.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:47 to leave the petition, poisoned the cordial, and left a docent pin by the tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I organized the anonymous staff petition against Sterling's plan to cut education programs for a private donor lounge. I was willing to embarrass him with signatures. Adrian saw me in the Grand Gallery while the poison was added. Museums are for people; murder is not public programming.

IF MURDERER

Sterling was going to build a private entrance by cutting the programs that let the public feel the museum belonged to them. I went in with the petition, poisoned his cordial, and lost my docent pin behind the table. I told myself I was protecting access. I destroyed something far more basic.

Investigation notes

Avery Lens

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling ordered you to surrender a photograph showing him meeting privately with Grant beside a shell-company shipping file.

What you are hiding

You kept a backup print after agreeing to delete the image from your camera. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- You photographed Sterling and Grant beside a shipping file marked NORTHSTAR earlier in the evening.
- Theo chipped a cufflink against the Grand Gallery rail during Act I.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Your continuous photo sequence shows you shooting Imogen in the gallery during the key window.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:44 to negotiate, poisoned the cordial, and left a torn photo corner by the service table.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I kept a backup print after agreeing to delete a photograph Sterling wanted gone. That is the secret I was protecting. My own continuous photo sequence proves I was photographing Imogen in the gallery while the drink was poisoned.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted an image erased because it showed him beside a shipping file he could not explain. I went into the salon to bargain, poisoned his cordial when he refused, and tore the backup print in the struggle to leave cleanly. A photographer should know better than to leave evidence in the frame.

Investigation notes

Juno March

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling had you removed from a previous museum event and threatened legal action if you disrupted tonight's unveiling.

What you are hiding

You planted small 'PROVENANCE IS A VERB' stickers in several gallery brochures for a peaceful protest. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Vivienne has been conducting quiet restitution talks connected to the exhibition.
- Marcus says Sterling suppressed provenance research rather than answer it.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Marcus was debating you in public during the entire critical window.

IF MURDERER

You slipped into the salon at 6:45, poisoned the cordial, and left adhesive backing from one of your stickers.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I planted small protest stickers in the museum brochures. That was the disruption I planned. Sterling had threatened legal action if I interfered with the unveiling, but Marcus and I were publicly arguing during the crucial minutes. My protest was supposed to make people look at the evidence, not become it.

IF MURDERER

Sterling treated every request for transparency as an attack on ownership. I slipped into the salon, poisoned his cordial, and dropped the backing from one of my protest stickers beneath the tray. I wanted an institution to return what did not belong to it. I crossed a line no cause gave me permission to cross.

Investigation notes

Penny Varnish

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

One decorative object in the exhibition once belonged to your family. You believe Sterling acquired it through a manipulative private sale decades ago.

What you are hiding

You brought old correspondence proving your family contested that sale and planned to confront him tonight. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Beatrice has old concerns about paperwork on Sterling's earliest donations.
- Sienna's relationship with Sterling has been unusually tense over family philanthropy.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Beatrice and Conrad were with you discussing the old sale during the key window.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:43, poisoned the cordial, and dropped one page of the old correspondence near the tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

My family contested the sale of an object Sterling later acquired, and I brought the old letters because I intended to confront him. I was not subtle about that. Sienna and Theo were with me at the centerpiece throughout the poisoning window. I came to reclaim a story, not take a life.

IF MURDERER

Sterling dismissed my family's letters as sentimental paperwork. I brought them into the salon, poisoned his cordial, and left one page beneath the glass. I have spent years collecting objects because stories cling to them. This page will carry mine forever.

Investigation notes

Leo Taggart

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling fed you several flattering claims for an earlier profile that you later discovered were exaggerated. He threatened to cut off access if you corrected them.

What you are hiding

You are preparing a correction that will also make you look embarrassingly credulous. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Nadia is preparing a major investigation involving Sterling's collection.
- Beatrice remembers the museum's early Voss acquisitions very differently from the current polished story.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Nadia's notes and Maya both place you in the dining room during the key minutes.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:46 for a quote, poisoned the cordial, and left your distinctive press pencil beneath the service table.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I repeated flattering claims Sterling fed me in an old profile, and I am preparing a correction that will make me look gullible. He threatened to cut off access if I ran it. Nadia's notes place me with her while the poison was added. Bad journalism is not murder, though tonight has made the distinction unusually comforting.

IF MURDERER

Sterling built part of his local legend by feeding me stories I was too pleased to verify. He planned to punish me for correcting them. I went in for one last quote, poisoned his cordial, and left my old press pencil beneath the tray. I wanted to revise the record. I became the headline.

Investigation notes

Riley Bloom

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling ordered you to add a gaudy lighting cue to the unveiling and threatened to withhold payment when Lucian objected.

What you are hiding

You secretly changed the cue again after approval, causing the eerie light flickers guests noticed during Act I. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Sterling borrowed heavily from Imogen's concept for the gala reveal.
- Lucian has been threatened with nonpayment over a last-minute display demand.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Lucian was with you adjusting the centerpiece lighting through the critical window.

IF MURDERER

You entered the salon at 6:44 to retrieve a lighting remote, poisoned the cordial, and left a gold ribbon fiber on the tray.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I secretly changed the approved lighting cue, which is why the centerpiece flickered so ominously during Act I. Sterling had demanded something gaudier, Lucian hated it, and I tried to split the difference without telling either of them. The lighting log puts me at the console when the drink was poisoned.

IF MURDERER

Sterling threatened not to pay unless I gave him the spectacle he wanted, then prepared to blame me for the result. I went into the salon under cover of retrieving a remote, poisoned the cordial, and left a gold ribbon fiber on the glass. I wanted one perfect gasp tonight. I got the wrong one.

Investigation notes
